

PROPOSAL

Integrated Commerce & Business Management Platform

A scalable, customizable commerce platform designed around the business — with retail, wholesale, vendor marketplace capabilities, centralized owner control, and automation.

Prepared for: Business Owner / Management

Purpose: Define the proposed direction, phased scope, system capabilities and discovery approach before final implementation budget and timeline are committed.

Executive positioning

The immediate priority is a fast, high-quality and highly customizable e-commerce experience. Around that commerce foundation, the platform will progressively support wholesale customers, multiple vendors, controlled marketplace listings, centralized inventory and operations, reporting, workflow automation and future AI capabilities.

Proposal principle: build the core correctly first, keep the architecture extensible, and introduce additional business modules as the requirements become clearer and the business validates them.

1. Executive Summary

The business is looking for more than a conventional online store. The intended solution is a central digital business platform where the website, products, orders, customers, vendors, pricing, inventory and operational workflows are connected.

The owner should be able to see and control the entire business from one administration layer, while the system handles repetitive work automatically. Important decisions such as vendor approval, product approval, pricing rules, exceptional orders and other sensitive actions should remain under configurable owner/admin control.

Because the full future feature set is not yet known, the recommended approach is a modular and extensible architecture. The project should begin with requirements discovery and solution design, followed by a focused Phase 1 commerce release. Further ERP, vendor, marketplace and automation capabilities can then be added without rebuilding the platform.

Primary objectives

- Excellent customer experience: fast, modern, responsive and conversion-focused e-commerce.
- Business flexibility: custom business rules rather than being constrained by a fixed e-commerce platform.
- Multiple sales models: retail, wholesale and future marketplace/vendor sales.
- Centralized control: Super Admin / Owner visibility over products, vendors, orders, pricing, inventory and approvals.
- Reduced manual effort: automate repetitive processes, notifications, approvals, stock updates and reporting where practical.
- Scalability: architecture that can support branches, warehouses, more vendors, new product categories and future integrations.
- Future readiness: provide a foundation for WhatsApp, AI/customer support and advanced automation after the core platform is stable.

2. Understanding of the Business Need

The owner is not expected to know every future ERP feature at this stage. The system should therefore be designed around confirmed business goals rather than forcing the business to finalize every future requirement before development begins.

Business priority	Proposed system response
Fast and high-quality website	Custom, performance-focused e-commerce frontend connected to the central commerce/data layer.
Highly customizable	Modular architecture, configurable workflows and business rules, avoiding unnecessary platform restrictions.
Multiple vendors	Vendor portal, vendor roles, product submission and controlled approval workflows.
Owner control	Super Admin control tower, role-based permissions, approval queues, audit trail and configurable controls.
Retail customers	Standard customer accounts, retail catalogue/pricing, checkout, payment and order tracking.
Wholesale customers	Wholesale account type, separate pricing rules, bulk ordering and configurable terms/approval.

Business priority	Proposed system response
Automation	Workflow/rules engine for operational tasks, alerts, notifications, approvals and scheduled processes.
Future growth	Branches, warehouses, marketplace, RMA, advanced reporting, integrations and AI can be added progressively.

3. Proposed Solution Architecture

The platform should be organized around a central business data and rules layer. The website, vendor portal and future sales channels should use the same controlled business services rather than maintaining disconnected product, inventory and order data.

Layer	Purpose
Customer Experience	Fast e-commerce website, product discovery, cart, checkout, customer account and order tracking.
Vendor Experience	Vendor registration, dashboard, product submission, stock/order views and controlled marketplace participation.
Admin / Owner Control	Central dashboard, approvals, users, products, vendors, pricing, orders, inventory, reports and configuration.
Commerce Engine	Customers, carts, orders, pricing, promotions, payments, fulfilment and customer lifecycle.
Inventory & Operations	Products, stock, warehouses, branches, purchasing, receiving, transfers, returns and RMA.
Workflow / Automation	Rules, triggers, approvals, notifications, scheduled jobs and exception handling.
Integration Layer	Payment gateway, shipping, WhatsApp, email/SMS, accounting and future external systems.
Data & Security	Central database, access control, audit logs, backups, monitoring and security controls.

Key design principle: one controlled source of truth for products, inventory, customers and orders, with multiple channels operating on top of it.

4. Core Functional Modules

Module	Initial / future capability
E-commerce	Homepage, catalogue, search, filters, product details, cart, checkout, customer account, order tracking, responsive UX and SEO foundation.
Product Management	Categories, brands, SKUs, variants, specifications, images, status, warranty information and configurable product attributes.
Customer Management	Customer profiles, order history, retail/wholesale classification, communication history and account controls.
Retail Pricing	Standard retail price, promotions/discounts and configurable pricing rules.
Wholesale	Wholesale customer accounts, separate pricing, bulk orders, customer-specific rules and optional approval/credit controls.
Vendor Management	Vendor registration, approval, roles, vendor profile, product submission, product approval and vendor controls.
Marketplace	Multiple sellers, seller products, commission/settlement rules, seller fulfilment and marketplace governance — later phase.
Inventory	Available, reserved, sold, damaged, returned and other configurable stock states; stock movements and reconciliation.

Module	Initial / future capability
Warehouse / Branch	Multiple locations, stock visibility, transfers, receiving and branch-level reporting — phased.
Purchasing	Vendors, purchase orders, receiving/GRN and procurement workflows — phased.
Orders	Online orders, payment status, fulfilment status, cancellation, returns and exception handling.
Payments	Payment gateway integration, payment status and reconciliation support.
Delivery	Shipping/delivery integration, tracking and customer notifications.
Reporting	Sales, orders, inventory, low stock, vendor, customer, branch and operational dashboards.
Automation	Rules, alerts, approvals, notifications, scheduled reports and process automation.
AI / Advanced Automation	Chatbot, AI customer support, intelligent search, AI reporting and assisted operations — later phase.

5. Phase 0 — Requirements & Solution Design

Because the owner has intentionally not finalized every future feature, the first stage should be a structured discovery and solution-definition exercise. This prevents unnecessary development and provides a reliable basis for implementation cost and schedule.

Activities

- Review existing website, backend, hosting and available software/data.
- Map current sales, purchasing, inventory, vendor and customer processes.
- Identify current pain points, manual activities and duplicated work.
- Define retail, wholesale and vendor business rules.
- Define owner/admin approval requirements and staff permissions.
- Define product, stock, order, vendor and customer data structures.
- Identify integrations and third-party dependencies.
- Define reporting and management visibility requirements.
- Identify automation opportunities and prioritize them by value and complexity.
- Create the future-state workflow, architecture and phased implementation roadmap.

Discovery deliverables

Deliverable	Outcome
Business Requirements Document	Agreed functional and business requirements.
Current-State Assessment	Documented existing systems, workflows and reusable components.
Future-State Workflows	Defined operational processes and approval flows.
Module Specification	Scope of each system module and priority.
Role & Permission Matrix	Who can view, create, approve, edit and administer each area.
Wireframes / UX Direction	Validated key website and admin user journeys.
Technical Architecture	Application, data, integration, hosting and security approach.
Data Migration Plan	Existing data assessment and migration approach.
Implementation Roadmap	Phases, dependencies and release sequence.
Commercial Estimate	Implementation effort, timeline, infrastructure and support assumptions.

6. Phase 1 — Commerce Foundation

Phase 1 should focus on the capability the owner is most certain about today: a strong customer-facing e-commerce platform with centralized administration and the foundations required for retail, wholesale and future vendor operations.

Area	Proposed Phase 1 scope
Website	Modern responsive UI, homepage, catalogue, search/filter, product pages, cart, checkout, customer account and order tracking.
Performance	Performance-focused frontend, optimized assets, caching strategy, efficient API/data access and monitoring.
Product Admin	Create/edit products, categories, brands, specifications, images, SKU and publication status.

Area	Proposed Phase 1 scope
Retail	Retail customer registration, retail pricing, orders, payment and fulfilment workflow.
Wholesale foundation	Wholesale customer type, account controls and separate wholesale pricing framework.
Inventory foundation	Central stock, stock availability, stock deduction/reservation and website synchronization.
Orders	Order dashboard, statuses, payment status, fulfilment status and basic cancellation/return handling.
Admin	Super Admin dashboard, staff accounts, roles, permissions and approval queues.
Reports	Core sales, orders, inventory and low-stock reporting.
Notifications	Email/SMS or selected notification integrations as agreed during discovery.
Security	Authentication, authorization, audit trail, secure configuration and backup strategy.

Phase 1 should establish the reusable foundation. Vendor marketplace, advanced ERP and AI should not be forced into the initial release unless discovery confirms that they are essential for launch.

7. Vendor & Marketplace Model

The vendor model should be designed as a controlled marketplace rather than simply allowing vendors to directly publish anything to the live store.

Step	Workflow
1. Registration	Vendor submits registration/application.
2. Super Admin review	Admin verifies and approves or rejects vendor access.
3. Vendor access	Approved vendor receives controlled portal access.
4. Product submission	Vendor enters product details, images, pricing and stock information.
5. Validation	System performs required data checks; admin review can be required.
6. Approval	Super Admin approves, rejects or requests changes.
7. Publication	Approved product becomes available according to configured rules.
8. Order processing	Orders are routed according to vendor/fulfilment rules.
9. Settlement	Commission, vendor amount and settlement status are calculated according to agreed rules.

Business rules requiring confirmation during discovery include vendor commission, seller ownership of stock, fulfilment responsibility, returns, warranty/RMA, product authenticity, customer ownership, settlement timing and seller service levels.

8. Retail, Wholesale & Pricing Engine

Pricing should be treated as a reusable business capability rather than a single fixed product price. This allows the business to introduce more pricing models later without redesigning the commerce platform.

Customer / Rule	Possible behavior
Retail	Standard public selling price.
Wholesale	Discounted or tiered price for approved wholesale accounts.
Customer-specific	Optional negotiated pricing for selected accounts.
Quantity-based	Price changes based on order quantity.

Customer / Rule	Possible behavior
Location-based	Different pricing or availability by location where required.
Vendor	Vendor-specific selling/commission rules where marketplace applies.
Promotion	Coupons, campaigns, bundles or time-bound discounts — subject to confirmed scope.

The exact pricing model should be finalized during discovery. The architecture should allow additional rules to be introduced later.

9. Inventory & Business Operations

Inventory is likely to become one of the central components of the platform. The system should distinguish product information from the actual stock items and stock movements.

Illustrative stock lifecycle

Stage	Example status
Purchase	Purchase order created.
Receiving	Goods received / pending verification.
Available	Available for sale.
Reserved	Reserved for an order.
Sold / Dispatched	Allocated and shipped.
Returned	Returned by customer.
Warranty / RMA	Under warranty, repair or replacement process.
Damaged / Quarantine	Not available for normal sale.

For refurbished or serialized IT products, discovery should confirm whether serial number, device identifier, condition, warranty, supplier, purchase cost and RMA history need to be tracked at item level.

10. Automation & Owner Control

Automation should reduce repetitive work without removing management visibility. The recommended platform therefore combines automation with approval gates, exception handling and auditability.

Automation area	Illustrative automation
Orders	Payment confirmation → reserve stock → create fulfilment task → notify customer.
Inventory	Sale → reduce/reserve stock → update availability → check low-stock rule.
Vendor	Product submission → validation → approval queue → publication after approval.
Wholesale	New wholesale account → approval → pricing group assignment.
Payments	Payment pending → reminder → escalation according to configured rules.
Delivery	Shipment created → tracking update → customer notification.
Reporting	Scheduled daily/weekly management reports.
Exceptions	Failed payment, stock mismatch, rejected product or delivery issue routed to responsible staff/admin.

The system should support a rules/workflow engine so that important business rules can evolve without requiring every change to be a new custom development project.

11. Super Admin / Owner Control

The owner's requirement for automation and full control should be treated as a core design principle.

- Central dashboard showing business activity and exceptions.
- Role-based access for employees, managers, warehouse staff, support teams and vendors.
- Approval workflows for vendors, products, selected orders and other sensitive actions.
- Configurable pricing and discount permissions.
- Audit logs showing important actions and changes.
- Ability to activate/deactivate vendors, products, users and selected capabilities.
- Exception queues showing items that require human attention.
- Reporting access according to role.
- System configuration controls reserved for authorized administrators.

The desired operating model is: automation handles repetitive work; staff handle operational tasks; management handles approvals, exceptions and decisions.

12. Recommended Implementation Roadmap

Phase	Focus	Indicative outcome
Phase 0	Requirements & solution design	Validated scope, workflows, UX direction, architecture, integrations, roadmap and commercial estimate.
Phase 1	Commerce foundation	Fast e-commerce website + central admin + product/order/inventory foundation + retail + wholesale foundation.
Phase 2	Vendor platform	Vendor registration, portal, product submission/approval, vendor operations and marketplace foundations.
Phase 3	ERP & operations	Purchasing, warehouses, branches, transfers, advanced inventory, RMA, advanced reporting and integrations.
Phase 4	Automation & AI	WhatsApp, advanced customer automation, AI support, intelligent reporting and other high-value automations.

This is a proposed roadmap, not a fixed commitment. The final phase boundaries should be confirmed after Phase 0 based on business priorities, dependencies and budget.

13. Integrations & Technology Decisions

The final technology stack and third-party services should be selected after requirements and technical discovery. The proposal should avoid committing to specific vendors before their requirements, cost and technical fit are validated.

- Payment gateway
- Shipping / delivery provider
- WhatsApp Business / messaging provider
- Email / SMS provider
- Existing inventory or backend system
- Accounting / GST / invoicing system, if applicable
- Analytics and monitoring
- Cloud hosting and storage
- Future AI / LLM services

Existing software, architecture and data should be assessed for reuse before deciding what must be rebuilt.

14. Security, Reliability & Performance

- Role-based access control and least-privilege permissions.
- Secure authentication and session management.
- Audit logs for sensitive administrative actions.
- Data backup and recovery strategy.
- Error monitoring and operational alerts.
- Performance monitoring for the customer-facing website.
- Secure handling of payment-related integrations; sensitive payment data should remain with appropriate payment providers where applicable.
- Environment separation for development, staging and production.

- Scalable infrastructure so traffic and catalogue growth can be accommodated.

15. Assumptions & Scope Protection

To keep the project commercially and technically controlled, the following principles are recommended:

- Final implementation cost and timeline will be based on the approved requirements and solution design.
- Features not included in an approved phase are not assumed to be included in that phase.
- Third-party subscription, API, hosting, messaging, payment and AI usage charges are separate unless explicitly included.
- Data migration effort depends on the quality, structure and volume of existing data.
- Existing systems will be assessed before reuse or replacement decisions are made.
- Marketplace settlement, tax, warranty, returns and vendor policies require business confirmation.
- AI/LLM features are optional later-stage capabilities and should be evaluated based on business value and operating cost.
- Major changes to approved workflows or scope may require revised effort and schedule.

Commercial note

The figures discussed informally during the business meeting should not be treated as confirmed implementation prices. They should be validated during requirements analysis and supplier/integration assessment before being included in the final commercial proposal.

16. Recommended Next Steps

Step	Action
1	Confirm this overall direction and business priorities.
2	Conduct a structured requirements workshop with the owner and key operational users.
3	Review existing website, backend, inventory and hosting setup.
4	Map retail, wholesale, vendor, inventory and approval workflows.
5	Define Phase 1 in sufficient detail for implementation.
6	Prepare wireframes and validate key user journeys.
7	Finalize technical architecture and integration choices.
8	Prepare detailed effort, timeline, infrastructure and support estimate.
9	Approve Phase 1 scope and commence implementation.

Closing Position

The recommended strategy is to avoid trying to predict and build the entire future ERP on day one. Instead, establish a strong and extensible commerce foundation, keep the owner in control, automate repetitive work, and progressively add vendor, wholesale, ERP and AI capabilities as the business validates each requirement.

Target outcome: a single platform that can grow from a high-performance e-commerce operation into a broader business management and marketplace ecosystem without requiring a fundamental rebuild.